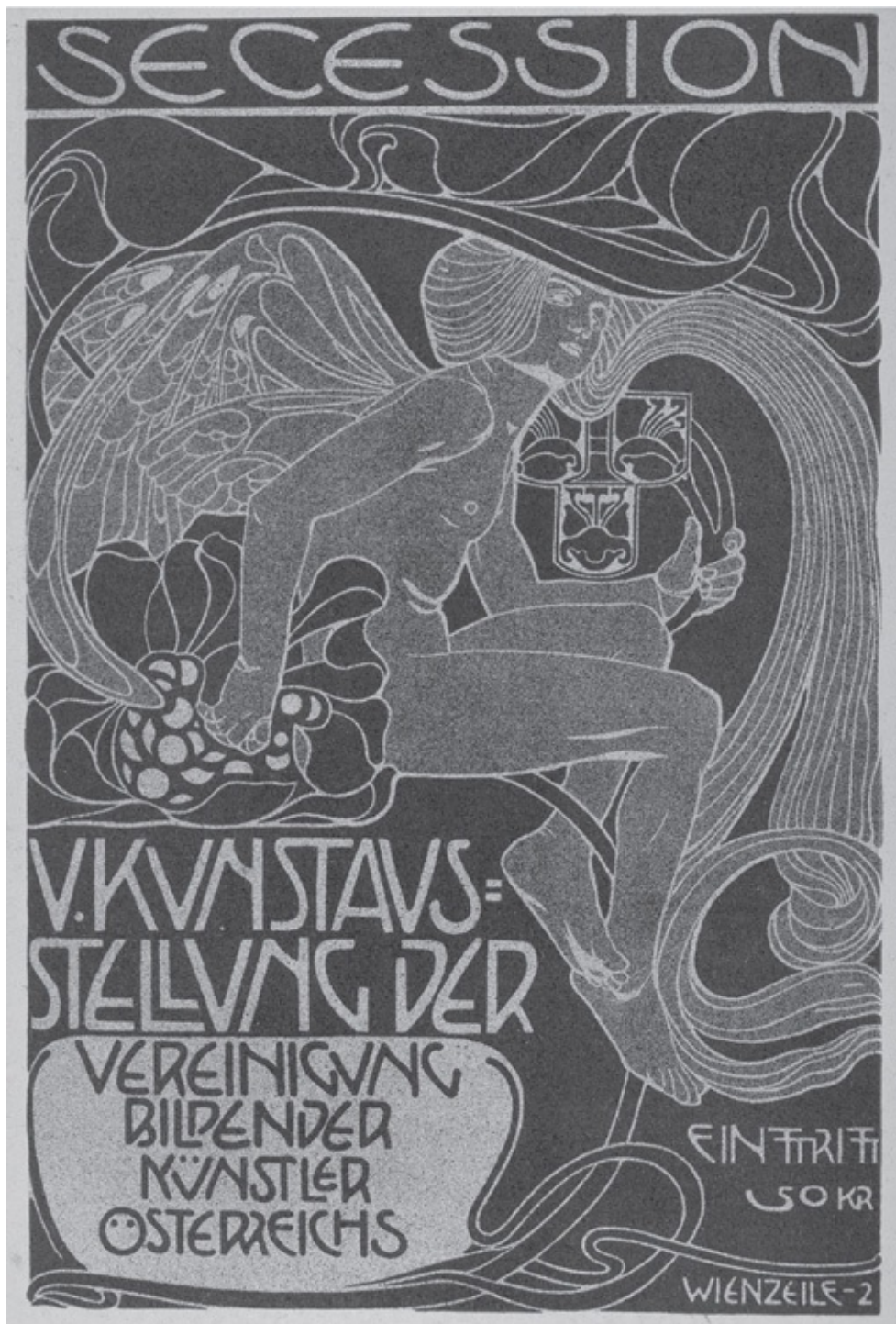


Vienna Secession

By 1897, Vienna was one of the largest cities in Europe, but its citizens were stifled by bureaucracy and old-fashioned attitudes to art. The only exhibition space was the Vienna Künstlerhaus, run by a conservative committee. A group of progressive young artists, designers and architects including Otto Wagner (1841–1918), Josef Hoffmann (1870–1956), Joseph Olbrich (1867–1908), Gustav Klimt and Koloman Moser (1868–1918) resigned from the Association of Austrian Artists to embrace new creative ideas, aiming to synthesize all the arts (mirroring with the aims of Art Nouveau). Announcing their aims, they said: 'We do not recognize any difference between great and minor art, between the art of the rich and that of the poor. Art belongs to all.'

Klimt became first president of this radical club, the 'Vienna Secession'. They published a periodical, *Ver Sacrum* ('Sacred Spring' in Latin), and constructed a new building as an exhibition space. Similar groups appeared around the same time in several European cities, but Vienna's was to be the most influential.



Moser, poster for Fifth Vienna Secession exhibition, 1899